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Principles of Correspondence

The ability to write a professional-sounding letter is a mark of business maturity. Business correspondence has a tone, pace, and attitude that takes some time to master; moreover, the largely unwritten rules of style differ markedly from country to country. The objective of this chapter, therefore, is to provide a framework for researching international correspondence cultures, as well as to caution against errors of style and etiquette that often afflict the letters and e-mails of North American business writers.

Business Letters: An Exercise in Style

Those of us who edit business communication would be just as happy if we never again saw the phrase *as per*. (*Per* is Latin for *as*.) Actually, we would not mind if *per* disappeared entirely from English business documents, except in such phrases as *miles-per-gallon*. This bit of adopted Latin (like *in re*) is an example of what I call *letter lingo*, words and phrases used by people writing memos or letters—and at no other time. Interestingly, no matter how often I urge my clients and students to replace these peculiar phrases (like *enclosed please find*), they resist. Their fear is that letters and memos without this stock parlance will not sound like real business writing, that omitting these words and phrases will make the writers appear inexperienced or unprofessional.

Although these fears are exaggerated, they do reflect the reality that part of being socialized into any professional culture, regardless of the country, is learning a new vocabulary (cant, argot, jargon, lingo, or patois) that defines one as an insider. In connection with letter and memo writing, there is not only a vocabulary but a structure—a standard sequence of parts/topics—as well as a small set of acceptable page layouts and formats. Not only do most image-conscious corporations take pains to design their letterhead (fancy name for *stationery*), they also usually specify the look, feel, and page layout as well: margins, tabs, typefaces/fonts, indentation, spacing, and location of letter elements on a page grid.

Now that possibly most business professionals type their own letters, it is harder than ever for companies to enforce their correspondence standards. Also, now that, at least in certain countries, e-mail exchanges—originally intended as little more than a replacement for short phone messages left on an answering machine—have begun to overwhelm all other forms of business correspondence, one might expect the imminent demise of the business letter as a sophisticated demonstration of good manners and professional language. Perhaps. But, as of this writing at least, in most of the world the business letter remains an exercise in style, a test of one's experience and one's ear for nuance.

Preparing international letters obliges E1 writers to think strategically about the mix of culture-free and culture-fair tactics in their messages. The differences across cultures—even within the larger countries—are not only many but also subtle. Toby Atkinson's indispensable Merriam-Webster's *International Business Communications* ably explains the scores of technical details that differentiate one country from another but says almost nothing about matters such as the appropriate tone to assume when breaking bad news to a partner, or whether that tone should be different for a French or Japanese audience. The style differences between countries are so subtle and elusive that, unless the E1 writer has the services of an expert consultant from the receiver's culture, it might be better to retain the sender's format and style, applying all the simplification, clarification, and culture-removing tactics mentioned so far.

The question that arises is whether to pursue the high-risk (therefore, potentially high-return) strategy of trying to write letters in the style of the recipient, even though it means considerable work, and even though there is a significant chance of error. Complicating matters is that the

interpretation of your “failure” will also vary from country to country. In some countries, your effort will be appreciated, whereas in others your failure will seem insincere, even meretricious.

The other option, again, is to play it safe: write readable, International English in one’s own format, knowing that the only penalty or “downside” is that one might give an advantage to the rival or competitor who uses the more difficult, localization strategy successfully.

Tactic 49: Eliminate Western Letter Lingo and Formats

Again, letter lingo refers to the special set of words (*per*), phrases (*enclosed find*), and syntax (*Should your travel plans* instead of *If your travel plans*) that seem to be used in correspondence and nowhere else. Apparently, the exclusive use of this small vocabulary in the formal letters of nearly every English-speaking country suggests that it is a legitimate part of the socialization of professional people in many professions. Oddly enough, nearly every teacher of business and professional writing urges against this style. Expressions such as *in re* or simply *re* (to mean *about* or *regarding*) are stilted, hackneyed, pretentious, and distracting. EIs simply do not talk that way (although I have heard more than a few *pers* slip into conversations). Moreover, they usually do not write that way either—except in letters and memos.

The inclination to use this style is an understandable part of the desire to fit in, to sound like one of the group. Entry-level employees quickly notice their company’s affectations of correspondence style and try to imitate them. So, for example, what would ordinarily be *last Thursday* is transmogrified into *Thursday last*. The mere fact that this style is noticeable and calls attention to itself should make it suspect to a thoughtful writer. Outside of the literary arts, good style should be invisible, never drawing attention from substance and meaning.

But what is the origin of the style itself? Why have so many gravitated toward this set of flat, boring verbal mannerisms? Probably, letter lingo emanates from the desire to sound as important and official as possible, especially in the opening line of the document. It is an imitation of how nonlawyers imagine lawyers write. But the style of writing generally disparaged as “legalese” is as disliked by good lawyers as by anyone else. Typically, when people try to impress their readers by imitating a lawyer, they end up imitating a mediocre or evasive lawyer instead. Usually, attempts to write in this style make one’s letters sound

less like legal documents than like the stultifying reports of police officers and insurance adjusters, or the opening and closing speeches of flight attendants—the only class of North American English speakers who still make extensive use of the subjunctive mood, as in *should there be a sudden change of cabin pressure*.

For those whose strategy is to write as simply and directly as possible, then, the first step is to replace letter lingo with plain English alternatives:

Before:

Per your request of 25 May, I am providing herein a response to your complaints re missing items.

After:

Here is an explanation of the missing items described in your May 25 letter.

Before:

Enclosed please find our response pursuant to your inquiry of March last. We hereby advise you, as per your request, that we will be sending said refund in due course under separate cover.

After:

We have received and read your letter written last March. We agree that you are entitled to a refund, which we will send you in just a few days.

When possible, E1s should strike the words *enclosed*, *attached*, and *referenced* from their correspondence. These stale, overused expressions—for example, *as referenced above*—are so predictable and uninteresting that they kill the attentiveness of the reader. They are most evident, incidentally, in cover letters and letters of transmittal, documents in which the date is the only real information. So, *attached please find* becomes *here is* or *this is*. If the goal is to produce a lean, culture-free document, it is also best to refrain from stock expressions of courtesy and politeness (*we regret, should the need arise, we trust*). In general, expressing emotions with standardized expressions sounds insincere.

If the E1 sender has decided not to emulate the letter style of the recipient, it may also be wise to eliminate the letter format altogether, replacing it with a trim, unmannered document that more resembles a memo. As already suggested in the earlier discussion on reducing burdens,

much of the material buried in paragraphs is better communicated to E2, and almost everyone else, as lists, tables, charts, or simple diagrams. But the letter format itself militates against these improvements. Although many letters contain lists, how many letters contain charts? or drawings?

The traditional letter is a prose-paragraph medium, loosely structured, a challenge for the reader. The modern memo, however, is a more tightly structured form, more comfortable with bullet lists and diagrams. Consider the following example, in which a typical, letter-lingo-filled, paragraph-based letter is replaced with a fully structured document:

Before:

Dear Task Force Members,

Pursuant to the questions raised at the last meeting of the Telecommunications Planning Team I have reviewed several alternative sites for our future meetings. This referenced the fact that several members of the Team found our Piscataway office inaccessible and inconvenient.

Per Todd's suggestion, I considered several options. Among these were a small office suite maintained by our company in Manhattan, our office in Pittsburgh, our office in Cincinnati, or hotel sites at the major New York airports: JFK, LaGuardia, and Newark. (I also weighed these sites against the current practice of holding the meetings here at HQ.) I evaluated these locations on several criteria. I was mainly interested in the travel time and travel costs for the Team members, but I was also concerned with the availability of the facilities and with whether they would have all the equipment and resources we use at our meetings, such as copy machines, fax hookups, etc.

What my analysis shows is that the cost of renting hotel space at an airport is much less than the added costs of car rentals, etc. Even if members from the Piscataway group have to drive to the meeting in a van, the savings in time and travel expenses are tremendous.

As a result I am recommending that we move the meetings to a hotel near JFK airport (either Embassy Suites or Courtyard). Since most of the team members fly USAir through JFK, this is the most convenient arrangement. We at Piscataway can bring some of the equipment we need in the van.

Should you have any reactions, please contact me at 201

After:
TO: Members of the Telecommunications Planning Team
ABOUT: Need to Change Site of Team Meetings to JFK Airport

RECOMMENDATION: We should hold future team meetings at an airport hotel near JFK Airport (Embassy Suites or Courtyard)

BACKGROUND: The Piscataway meeting site is inaccessible to everyone but people who work at Piscataway.

ALTERNATIVES:

- Manhattan office
- Pittsburgh office
- Cincinnati office
- Newark Airport
- LaGuardia Airport
- JFK Airport
- Piscataway office (status quo)

CRITERIA:

- Travel time for participants
- Travel costs for participants
- Availability of facilities
- Cost of facilities
- Resources available at site (copier, fax, etc.)

ANALYSIS: I recommend the JFK site for the following reasons:

- It is best for all but the Piscataway members (3 of 9).
- It costs much less than the travel costs it saves.
- It is the most available plan.
- The lack of resources can be accommodated by bringing equipment from Piscataway.

ACTION: Please write, fax, or e-mail at once to say whether you approve or disapprove of this plan.

Almost any reader would prefer the latter version, especially since the gist of it can be learned from reading no more than the subject line. But there are many situations—perhaps most—when such an austere, undecorated message would communicate the wrong attitude and deference.

Tactic 50: Adopt the Receiver's Format

To localize the format of a letter for a particular E2 country, E1 can either consult one of the published compendiums of international styles, such as the Merriam-Webster guide mentioned earlier, study a text devoted to the business practices of the particular country, or merely collect a few samples, most usefully from the company you intend to write to. With this material in hand, the next step is to develop a sample or model to follow, a template, with illustrations of the following items:

- General Page Appearance—How much of the page, and which parts, should be allocated to headings and documentation, as opposed to body text; how much white space; what typefaces, leading (spacing), and font size?
- Letterhead Conventions—Where should the identification of the sender's organization appear; what is an appropriate size; what colors are inappropriate; how commercial should the headers and footers be (would it be too brash to include tag lines in the letterhead, for example); what information should be provided?
- Date Line—Where should the date appear; in what format?
- Internal Address—Where should the recipient's name and address appear; what titles, honorifics, or position descriptions should be included; should any information other than the mailing address be included, like e-mail and fax information? (Note: Under no circumstances should any business letter misspell the name of its recipient; any cost required to verify title, name, and spelling is well spent.)
- Return Address—Where, other than the letterhead, should the sender's return address appear; should any information other than the mailing address be included (like e-mail and fax information)?
- Subject Line(s)—Should the letter contain one or more subject lines; should there be a subject line that identifies the account or file associated with the correspondence; should there be a line linking this message to another (*In reply to*)?
- Salutation—How does one address the recipient; what titles, greetings, and honorifics are preferred; how does one manage the problem of unknown gender; does one address men and women recipients differently?

- **Body Text**—What is the preferred form of indentation and paragraph separation; are there barriers against bullets, side headings, or other structured forms?
- **Complimentary Closing**—What polite phrase is typically used before the sender’s signature; are special meanings associated with different closings?
- **Signature/ID**—How should the senders identify themselves; how are the printed and hand-written signatures alike and different; are there rules for including one’s job position or university degrees in the signature?
- **Reference Initials**—Is it appropriate to identify the author and typist with initials; does the recipient include other codes for identifying responsibility?
- **Attachment ID, Page Numbers, and Other Documentation**—Is it customary to number pages on a letter that exceeds a page; are there conventions for items that appear after the signature or in the footer to help file and manage the document, such as version numbers, project numbers, authorization codes, reviewers/censor’s codes?
- **Outside (Envelope) Address**—What is the precise sequence of company, person, street address, postal code, and so forth? (Note: An error here can frustrate the automated mail processing system in that country, adding one or several days’ delay.)

This list should illustrate how subtle and complex it is to localize just the format of the letter. Consider these representative samples of the many subtle variations in expected format:

France Sample:
Edmond H. Weiss
Fordham Business School
113 West 60 Street
New York, New York
10023 USA

M. Jean Louis
Director of Training
DeGaulle Ltd.
Morne Jaloux Place
6000 Paris

New York 15 August 2004

Sir,

Texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext.

Texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext.

Coordinator of Intercultural Program
Edmond H. Weiss

Saudi Arabia Sample (both correspondents are Muslims):

Youssef Al-Wadi
Madina Conference Center
112 Cadde-ul sehr, Madina
Kingdom of Saudi Arabia

15 August 2004

Bismillahirrahmanirrahim
Esselamun aleykum ve
rahmetulla

Dear Brother,

Texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext. Texttexttexttext
texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
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Texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
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texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext.

Esselamun aleykum ve rahmetulla

Ahmet Hour
Global Training Systems
New York, United States of America

Japan Sample:

August 15, 2004

Dr. Taskashi Kobyasha
Manager of Planning
Tokyo Business
Development Council
15-17 Ginza 9 chome
Chuo-ku Tokyo 104

Dr. Edmond Weiss
President
Crown Point
Communications
2000 Cooper Road
Crown Point,
New Jersey 03001

Dear Dr. Kobyasha:
Texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext.

Texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
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texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext texttexttexttext
texttexttexttext texttexttexttext.

Sincerely yours,
<signature>
Edmond H. Weiss
President

Tactic 51: Emulate the Receiver's Opening Paragraph and Customary Closing

American business communication consultants agree on most things but not on how to begin a business letter. Specifically, the most divisive question is how to start the presentation of bad news. (Nearly everyone has more trouble writing bad news correspondence than good news.) The first sentence or two of a bad news letter is usually called the “buffer” because its purported function is to soften the blow or ameliorate the pain in the message. Everyone who has ever been turned down for a job, loan, or favor has seen a buffer:

- Thank you for submitting your excellent resume . . .
- We read your application with great interest . . .
- Thank you for your generous offer to . . .

Buffers are a noble idea, an antidote for the blunt, insensitive way that some people write. After decades of their use, however, some of us have come to challenge their efficacy, especially when they are couched in clichés and stock phrases. In other words, the goal of showing concern for the recipient of bad news is ill served by hackneyed language that suggests a lack of a genuine interest in the recipient of the bad news.

The buffer battle rages on, however. Most Americans are simply afraid of beginning a letter by saying: *We hired someone else for the Coordinator's position.* And those writers are somewhat better prepared to communicate in the local letter styles of other countries. With few exceptions, every country's letter culture expects some ritual expression of feeling or some philosophical observation in the opening paragraph. (I recently received an e-mail from Pakistan that began: *I hope you will be safe and sound.*) Those EIs who are eager to get directly to their actual business (as I am when I have bad news to deliver) must restrain themselves and learn the appropriate local etiquette.

There are several ritualized openings, depending on the country. Most fit into these categories:

- Solicitation of the recipient's well-being (Careful: In some countries it is taboo to inquire about the recipient's family, especially a man's wife)
- Grateful recollection of past meetings, especially of the last visit to the recipient's country

- Reflection on the changing of the seasons, or of a current holiday or festival, or the anniversary of a historically significant event
- Comments on the beauties of nature, especially in the recipient's homeland at this time of year
- Homage to the importance or accomplishments of the recipient, the recipient's company or government or country
- Philosophical or religious commentary, including proverbs or quotes from appropriate scriptures or literature

The options for concluding are fewer, but they, too, are ritualized. Most letters end with an indication of what comes next, if anything. In some countries, however, it is bad form to mention future meetings or events without a humble disclaimer acknowledging divine will.

Although there may come a day when casual e-mail will supplant this demonstration of politesse, for now, one of the central chores for those somewhat rough-hewn North Americans who wish to localize their letters for the rest of the world is to learn how to pay a compliment, speak sincerely of nature's beauty, or offer a philosophical insight.

Tactic 52: Emulate the Receiver's Content Restrictions

Various countries also have different traditions regarding the content of letters. In some places, for example, the prices of goods and services should NOT be documented in writing, since that would foreclose the eventual spoken negotiation and bargaining process. Els should learn the negotiation cultures in the recipient's country to determine whether hard numbers, black on white, would help or hinder the process. Such research should be in-depth and country-specific. Two works that provide a broad framework for this preparation are Dean Foster's *Bargaining across Borders* and Jeffrey Curry's *A Short Course in International Negotiating*.

Some countries, notably Mexico, expect a letter to be filled with personal information and expressions of sentiment, whereas others, including Switzerland, want only hard, cold facts committed in writing. Too much intimacy in the letter might suggest a biased business decision. As already noted, certain favored topics, such as references to the seasons, recur in the letters of certain countries, whereas other topics—even certain words—are taboo. To repeat an extremely sensitive

point, in some countries one is thanked for asking about the well-being of the recipient's family members; in others, Saudi Arabia, for example, the very word *wife* will provoke an angry response.

Note that national borders and the legitimacy of governments are in dispute throughout the world, making it an unspeakable blunder to take the wrong side through one's choice of words. For example, Microsoft Corporation referred to Taiwan as a "country" in one of its setup utilities and alienated the People's Republic of China. Similarly, in a graphical representation of the world map it resolved the Kashmir conflict by making its one pixel the same color as that of one of the disputant countries (India and Pakistan). Both of these lapses, small to Western eyes, were serious enough problems to warrant correction in the next version of the software.

Complicating matters, in many parts of the world there is a so-called disconnect between what everyone knows and what one is permitted to speak or write. For instance, one government may officially not recognize another, but may secretly have diplomatic and business relationships. If E1's business communication is part of that unspoken dynamic, it limits what may be written and forces E1s to use certain oblique, almost obfuscating language, like calling an embassy an "interest center" or "trade delegation." Currently, for example, the outsourcing of American technical and administrative jobs to India and China has become a politically sensitive topic. Not surprisingly, then, the companies that broker and provide these services are using names and descriptions that give no clue to what they do.

Moreover, in many cultures business is not really conducted in writing at all. These so-called high-context cultures rely more on unexpressed understandings than written agreements. Some countries have unofficial or secret political and business relationships, in which there is a separate version of the truth for public and private consumption. In addition, there are clandestine cultures in which business is actually conducted through exchange of favors, purchase of influence, and political manipulation, in which bids and contracts are just for show.

We should note that part of cultural sensitivity lies in refraining from characterizing these practices as dishonest or evil. One person's bribe is another's sales commission or broker's fee. In the United States, for example, bribes to government officials are usually in the form of campaign contributions. And there are times when progress can be made only in secret because of overwhelming political or ethnic pressures.

Remember that writing is a kind of frozen or captured speech, which in many cases is nearly permanent. Two persons may nullify one another's recollection of what was spoken in a negotiation, but hard copy is difficult to deny. For that reason, much international correspondence and documentation must be written in a code—if not in outright falsehoods. Those who are uncomfortable with these ground rules may elect to resign from the game.

What about E-mail?

Before the mid-1990s, e-mail systems tended to be within companies or single-purpose networks. E-mail messages were usually short, limited to plain text (sometimes all upper case), and incidental to the many other forms of business and corporate communication. Even when that changed, though, when everyone had learned the syntax of the @ sign, the uses of email were still circumscribed: generally, two- or three-sentence texts resembling the short messages we had only recently learned to leave on telephone answering machines.

By the end of the twentieth century, however, those who taught and studied business communication found e-mail increasingly interesting and worrisome. On the one hand, people were writing again; professionals who previously did all their communicating on the telephone, who rarely sent a memo or wrote a letter, increasingly spent a good part of each day writing and reading. On the other hand, the rough and reckless e-mail approach to writing—disregard for standard spelling, grammar, capitalization, or punctuation, (along with cryptic abbreviations and acronyms like BTW)—filled the stewards of proper English with alarm.

E-mail is more than a channel or medium or technology. It is a communication culture of its own, offering global interaction at nearly the speed of light, while discounting the stylized, mannered, formal culture of traditional professional communication. Although recent technology makes available every kind of formatted text and graphical layout, even though a contemporary e-mail message can contain not only dynamic links to changing data but also animated graphical presentations of those changes, most e-mail is still rough and reckless plain text, much of it written without the use of the <SHIFT> key.

It avails English teachers and communication consultants little to rail against this decline. We can warn our clients that e-mail needs to be reread, edited, and refined before it is sent; we can cite research showing that most of the substandard English in e-mails works against the

professional interests of the senders. But most e-mail users are unimpressed with these arguments. They are not only unapologetic but insurgent; they hold that the quick, no-frills way of communicating is inherently better than the polite alternatives.

In any case, those who use e-mail to pursue serious professional and business objectives—as opposed to casual, friendly exchanges—should be mindful of certain rules of structure and etiquette that affect the reliability of the medium. For example,

- Date and Time can be expressed in several forms, but, as mentioned before, certain American dating conventions produce anomalous results. (2/7/09 is a winter day in New York and a summer one in Germany.) Also, international e-mails should include not only the local time of origin, but also GMT (Greenwich Mean Time, or Greenwich Meridian Time, also known as Universal Time). GMT is the local time in London but is not adjusted for Daylight Saving Time. It is five hours later than Eastern Standard Time in the United States.
- Subject Lines must be clear and complete enough to attract the attention of the reader. Only those who are new to e-mail open all their messages; most businesspeople and professionals delete unwanted and uninteresting messages before they read anything. Subject lines, therefore, must be substantive and interesting. Instead of *Meeting Update* write *Revised date for Project Launch* or, better, *Project Launch moved to 15 October*. Instead of *ISO Status* write *ISO registrars promise report by May*.
- Body text should contain short sentences and short paragraphs. When possible, lists and simple tables should replace paragraphs, and widely available ASCII symbols (>, =, #) should be used to serve as bullets and emphasis devices.
- Unsolicited sales material is never acceptable in international e-mails. For most Westerners “junk e-mail” or “spam” is an irritant, but in most of the world it is regarded as an unforgivable breach of business etiquette and will make further relationships impossible. One should always send a one- or two-sentence e-mail first, asking permission to send the longer sales material or business proposal.

Adapting E-mail for International Recipients

The question is whether e-mail culture is suitable for International English exchanges or whether, for example, it is better to attach a fully

formatted, traditional letter to a one-line e-mail letter of transmittal. The answer is complicated by various stages of e-mail development and forms of e-mail culture in the many nations of the world. Those countries with a long tradition of letter writing, in which the art and craft of the letter are key parts of a young person's education, may be expected to find Western e-mail culture brusque and unsophisticated (like the cut-to-the-chase American sales presentation). Furthermore, those countries with a tradition of exceptional postal service (like the UK) or with an official government commitment to preserving correct diction and grammar (like France) might be put off by receiving important correspondence in the casual, plaintext e-mail style.

There is no obvious choice, however. Attitudes toward e-mail culture vary by industry as much as by country and, it appears, by the age of the correspondents. E-mail is also part of the phenomenon called *leapfrog* technology in which a country undergoing rapid economic or social development will skip one generation of technology and go directly to a more advanced one. Countries without a landline infrastructure, for example, may go directly to wireless phones and satellite TV systems. Similarly, countries without a tradition of business letter writing or formalized business speech may leap directly to the informal, casual e-mail approach.

The purpose of this discussion is not to assess the appropriateness of using e-mail. Nearly everyone in the word enjoys the breathtaking speed and convenience of this form of communication. Rather, the question is whether to use e-mail in the loose, energetic style that most people associate with the technology or, alternately, use it just as another channel to transmit either carefully globalized or expensively localized business messages. And, if the latter, how?

First, if research shows that the E2 recipient is comfortable with speedy, plaintext e-mail, does not find it inappropriately informal for the business at hand, it is still necessary to apply most of the tactics discussed in this text. Even though the style is informal and the text largely unformatted, the message is still being sent to someone who finds it at least somewhat difficult to read English and who may need to consult a bilingual dictionary. *Until* and *mind* are still hard words to translate; *I am waiting* is still harder to understand than *I wait*; *key player*, *put up with*, and *prewireless* are hard to look up. This means that, at the very least, an International English e-mail should be studied and edited before the writer hits the <Send> key.

If E1 decides to send a traditional letter, especially one localized to the format and content preferences of the recipient, there are still other questions:

- Are attachments safe and welcome? Does the recipient's e-mail system discourage attachments or even block them. Is the recipient's e-mail system fast enough to download larger attachments, without annoying the receiver and tying up the resources? Will the attachment travel reliably; that is, will the formatting and numbering be distorted by the several bounces of the document through the global communication network?
- Is it feasible to send formatted plain text? In the early days of computing, skillful programmers could generate clever graphics composed of thousands of the letter *x* and a few equal signs. To format plain text well takes ingenuity—after all, there are not even bullets. But a moment or two can make a string of uninviting characters far more accessible and readable.

The example that follows shows how small changes in plain text can make an e-mail far easier to read.

Unformatted Plain Text

Jack . . . The meeting went as planned. Audrey had three objections to the proposed date for the next conference—the conflict with IEEE convention, the short time to solicit and evaluate papers and presentations, the fact that we need a new printer since the company we used last year has raised its prices too high. We also agreed that the four programs at the conference would be Voice Command Recognition, Voice-Based Security Systems, Machine Translation of Arabic, Research & Development Priorities. Jan complained, by the way, that most of the presentations last year were just commercials for consultants and we would need better science and analysis this year.

Formatted Plain Text

```
=====
To: Jack
Subject: 2006 Speech Recognition Conference Planning
=====
OBJECTIONS TO DATE (Audrey)
>> The conflict with IEEE convention dates
>> The short time to solicit and evaluate papers and presentations
>> The need to secure a new printer
***The company we used last year has raised its prices too high.***
```

OBJECTIONS TO CONTENT (Jan)

>> Most of the presentations last year were just commercials for consultants

>> We would need better science and analysis this year

=====

Proposed Program

=====

- o Voice Command Recognition
- o Voice-Based Security Systems
- o Machine Translation of Spoken Arabic
- o Research & Development Priorities.

- Is it feasible to embed a fully formatted document based on SGML or XML (two of the most widely-used hypertext markup languages)? When attachments are a problem, and plain text is too limiting, the best course is to embed or insert a “marked-up” hypertext document in the e-mail panel. This process grows easier with each generation of word processing software and allows the senders to make as refined a letter as they wish. Again, the senders should be sure that there is no barrier to hypertext documents at the receiver’s end, especially as more and more organizations are blocking potential computer viruses by disabling certain hypertext features.

Most business letters communicate a small, important objective in a key passage or two, which is then surrounded by mannerism, affectation, ritual, tradition, and even a bit of deception. Unfortunately, if this ornamental, content-free material surrounding the core content is handled badly—for example, if a title is wrong, if there is insufficient deference, or if the wrong holiday sentiment is expressed—the sender can fail to achieve the business objective. Informal e-mail culture may change this some day. Indeed, the coarse communication style nowadays associated with Instant Messages and cell phone “texting” may some day cause us to remember fondly the more polite and readable style of e-mails!

But not for a while.

Discussion Questions

- Do you currently send memos to your colleagues and associates? in what circumstances?
- How do you feel when you read the buffer of a bad news letter? Does it help?

- Are you comfortable writing buffers? paying compliments? commenting on the season?
- Do you receive more than an occasional business letter? in what circumstances?
- Do you reread and revise your e-mails before you send them? How much time do you spend on a typical email message? Is it enough?
- Have you ever been embarrassed by the substandard grammar and spelling in your e-mails?
- Have you ever judged an unknown person by the care or carelessness of his or her e-mails?

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